and January, they seem to have missed that bus," he says.

The BJP, after its sweep of all seven Delhi seats in the 2024 general election, believes 2025 is its best chance to win Delhi, but as a party insider puts it, "it's also our toughest one." The party is banking on ten years of anti-incumbency as well as what it hopes is Kejriwal's tainted anti-corruption image from the excise policy scandal. Add to that the exit of many loyal leaders from AAP, weakening its position in several constituencies. The BJP's strategy is multifaceted: field heavyweight candidates, challenge AAP's welfare model and outpromise AAP on freebies. The party released its manifesto in three volumes two weeks before the polling date of February 5. First, BJP chief J.P. Nadda and former Union minister Anurag Thakur released two volumes with the themes of Garib (poor), Yuva (youth) and Naari (women). In these, the BJP committed a raft of freebies, including Rs 2,500 for every adult woman in poor families, an additional Rs 5 lakh as health insurance cover apart from the Rs 5 lakh under Ayushman Bharat, subsidy amounts of Rs 500 on LPG cylinders and one free cylinder each during Holi and Diwali. Then, Union home minister Amit Shah released the third and final volume listing commitments to create 50,000 government jobs and two million self-employment opportunities, provide 100 per cent e-buses by 2027, cleaning up the Yamuna and a blueprint for the capital to become a hub for entrepreneurship and industry.

Reviving fortunes in the 2025 Delhi election is crucial for the Congress not just for survival but also to regain its credibility within the Opposition bloc



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

FINDING SPACE Rahul Gandhi leads the Congress campaign in Delhi's Patparganj neighbourhood, Jan. 28

SAFFRON'S SURGICAL STRIKES

The BJP has been surgical in its approach to candidate selection. By nominating prominent leaders like two-time MPs Parvesh Verma to take on Kejriwal in New Delhi and Ramesh Bidhuri to take on Atishi in Kalkaji, the party is signalling serious intent designed to challenge AAP's strongholds. "There is no fight," says a confident Parvesh Verma, while campaigning in Ansari Nagar AIIMS campus. Son of former Delhi chief minister and Jat strongman Sahib Singh Verma, Parvesh, by virtue of fighting Kejriwal directly, is widely believed to be a frontrunner for the CM's post should his party win. In an election where the BJP has characteristically not projected a CM face, "*Aashirwad dijiyega* (please bless me)," he tells residents of Ansari Nagar, as he goes door to door in the company of local BJP workers. They tear down Kejriwal posters and replace them with Verma's as they walk. The quiet of the evening is punctured by drumbeats and slogans. Women peek out of windows and balconies as Parvesh waves. A cutout of Kejriwal stands at the entrance of his house in Windsor Place. "Don't vote for me, I failed to clean the Yamuna," it says, mocking a promise Kejriwal has not kept. "I will be immersing this cutout in the Yamuna," Verma says, proceeding to do exactly that the next day.

The BJP is hoping to make a dent in Kejriwal's core base and is focusing on lower middle class areas, JJ clusters and slums, where the local units of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) have become active. Spread across 675 slums and over 1,700 jhuggi-jhopri (JJ) clus-